INV-008 · The 1973 Invoice

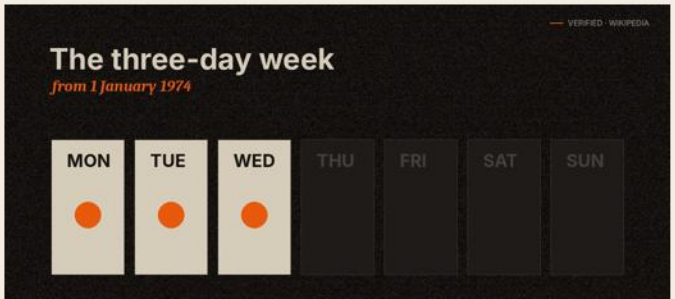
Storyboard v1 · ledger look (same kit as INV-007)

- Script v1: 89 paragraphs · 2442 words · about 19 min of voice, ~20 min cut (can grow to ~30)
- Mix by narration time: graphics 62% · video 19% · photos 19% (target 50 / 30 / 20)
- Every video clip and photo matches the line being spoken. If no match is found, the shot becomes a graphic.
- No 'Illustration' label on screen (YouTube's synthetic-content box is still ticked at upload).
- Photos and clips in this storyboard are first picks from Pixabay; final clips are fetched per line before render.
- Then every paragraph in order, with a grade label under each photo or clip.















Oregon, the winter of 1973. A green flag hangs on a petrol pump. Green means you can buy fuel. Yellow means rationed. Red means there's nothing left.

PHOTO **CO-01** COLOUR · CALM

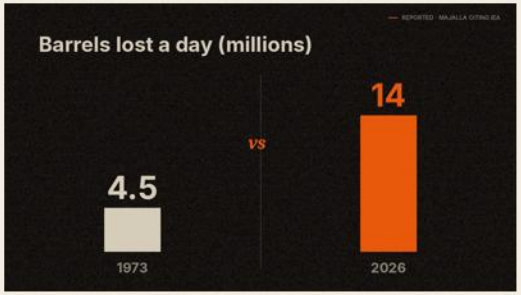
Old petrol pump at a roadside station, winter light, slow push; small flag colour shifts green → yellow → red. + label 'OREGON · WINTER 1973'



This was the 1973 oil crisis. In a few months, the price of a barrel of oil went up about four times. By February 1974, one American petrol station in five had nothing to sell.

GRAPHIC **CO-02**

Split-flap board rolls $2.90 → $11.65; row of 5 pump icons, one goes dark



Here's the strange part. In the 1973 oil crisis, the world lost about four and a half million barrels a day. In 2026, it lost more than fourteen million. Three times as much. And the queues never came.

GRAPHIC **CO-03**

Two cut-paper barrel stacks: 4.5M (1973) vs 14M+ (2026, orange)



But the bill did. A gallon of petrol in America costs about a dollar more than it did a year ago. In 1974, it rose forty-three percent in thirteen months.

VIDEO **CO-04** COLOUR · INTENSE

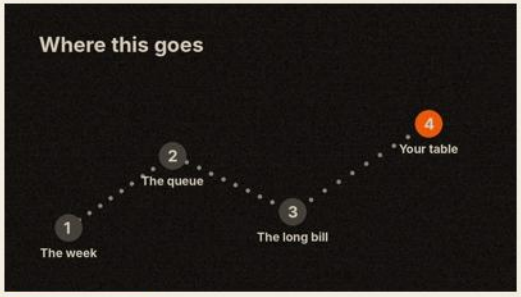
Modern petrol pump display ticking up (toned) + corner '+$1' + label; 2 s receipt flash



Some of these numbers are old government records. Some are reporting from this year that can still change. We'll tell you which is which, every time.

GRAPHIC **CO-05**

Three typed tag cards fan out with stamps VERIFIED · REPORTED · ESTIMATE



By the end, you'll see the full invoice from 1973, line by line, next to ours. We'll start with the week it began, stand in the queue, sit in the dark in Britain, follow the long bill, see what the world fixed, and come back to your table.

GRAPHIC **CO-06**

Roadmap: six stops light in a row



Part one. The week it started.

GRAPHIC **P1-01**

Part card 01 'The Week It Started'



In August 1973, Saudi Arabia's King Faisal and Egypt's President Sadat met in Riyadh. They agreed that oil could be used as a weapon.

GRAPHIC **P1-02**

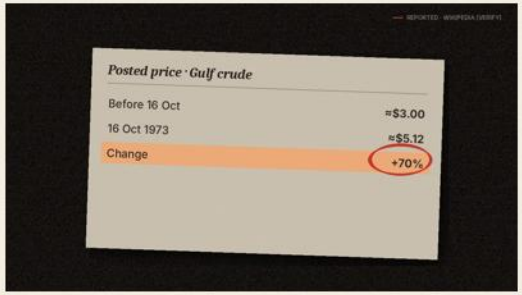
Dark map: Riyadh pin, thin orange line to Cairo; serif 'the oil weapon'



On the sixth of October, war broke out between Israel, Egypt and Syria. Within a week, the United States began flying weapons to Israel.

GRAPHIC **P1-03**

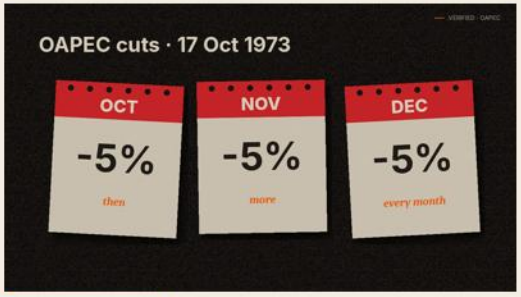
Timeline: 6 OCT war · 12-14 OCT US airlift (map arrows only, no combat)



Then came the oil. On the sixteenth of October, Gulf producers raised their price by about seventy percent, in one day.

GRAPHIC **P1-04**

Document: posted price sheet, 16 Oct line circled red '+70%'



On the seventeenth, Arab producers cut output by five percent. And they said they would cut five percent more, every month, until their demands were met.

GRAPHIC **P1-05**

Calendar pages tear off: -5% · -5% · -5%



Two days later, President Nixon asked Congress for two point two billion dollars in emergency aid for Israel. Libya announced an embargo on the United States that same day. Saudi Arabia followed the next.

GRAPHIC **P1-06**

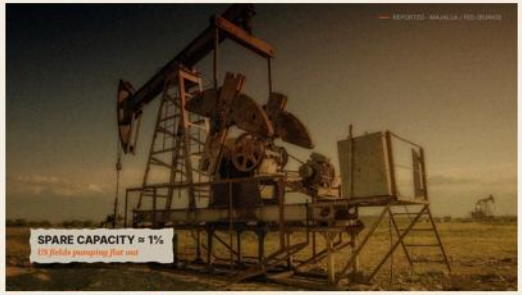
Newspaper clipping recreation 'ARABS CUT OFF OIL TO U.S.' style (paraphrased, outlet-free), date 20 OCT 1973



The embargo hit the US and the Netherlands first. Later Portugal, Rhodesia and South Africa were added. No oil from Arab producers was to reach them.

GRAPHIC **P1-07**

World map: US + Netherlands red, then Portugal, Rhodesia, South Africa



Why did it bite so hard? Because there was almost no slack. Before the embargo, the world had about one percent of spare production. America's own oil fields were already pumping flat out.

VIDEO **P1-08** COLOUR

Oil pumpjacks working in a field (toned) + gauge overlay 'SPARE ≈ 1%'



So the price did what prices do when there is no slack. A barrel cost about two dollars ninety before the embargo. By January 1974, it cost eleven sixty-five. Four times as much.

GRAPHIC **P1-09**

Line chart $2.90 → $11.65, Oct 1973 → Jan 1974



In today's money, that's roughly twenty-two dollars a barrel, rising to about eighty. Keep that eighty in mind. We'll come back to it.

GRAPHIC **P1-10**

Price tags: $22 → $80 (2026 dollars), faded originals behind



At the pump, the jump was slower but it was real. In May 1973, an American gallon of petrol cost thirty-eight and a half cents. By June 1974, fifty-five cents. Forty-three percent in thirteen months.

PHOTO **P1-11** COLOUR

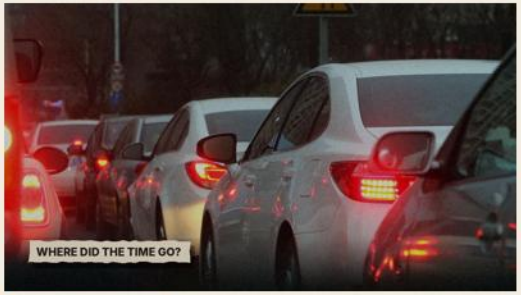
Close-up of an old mechanical petrol pump dial / price wheels, slow push + corner '55.1¢'



Take a family that bought sixty gallons a month. That's an example, not an average. They paid about ten dollars more a month. In today's money, about sixty-eight dollars. Every month, for fuel alone.

GRAPHIC **P1-12**

Receipt prints line 1: FUEL +$68/MONTH (example family)



But money wasn't the first thing people lost. The first thing was time. So where did the time go?

VIDEO **P1-13** COLOUR · INTENSE

Line of cars waiting at a station / traffic queue, slow (toned) + label 'WHERE DID THE TIME GO?'



Part two. The queue.

GRAPHIC **P2-01**

Part card 02 'The Queue'



On the twenty-fifth of November, Nixon went on television. He warned that the shortage could reach seventeen percent.

PHOTO **P2-03** COLOUR

Vintage television set in a dim living room, slow push + quote line '...as high as 17 percent'



If you want to see how today's crises reach your bill, that's what this channel does, every video. Subscribe, and next we'll follow the war to your dinner plate.

GRAPHIC **BR-01**

Envelope card 'NEXT INVOICE · The Hunger Bill'



On the seventh of November 1973, the White House announced Project Independence. The goal was for America to need no foreign oil. That was the plan for later. The problem was the winter.

GRAPHIC **P2-02**

Notice card: 'PROJECT INDEPENDENCE · 7 NOV 1973', stamp GOAL



He asked stations to close from nine on Saturday night to midnight on Sunday. He asked homes to turn the heating down to sixty-eight degrees. Home heating oil would be cut by fifteen percent.

PHOTO **P2-04** COLOUR

Hand turning a home thermostat down, slow push + three focus chips



About nine in ten station owners went along with the weekend closing. So everyone tried to fill up on the other days, at the same time.

VIDEO **P2-05** COLOUR

Closed petrol station / empty forecourt with a sign, toned



Some states turned to odd and even days. If your licence plate ended in an odd number, you bought fuel on odd dates. Even numbers, even dates.

GRAPHIC **P2-06**

Licence plate last digit flips 3 → 4; calendar odd/even



In the last week of February 1974, one station in five across the country had no fuel at all. People left home before dawn to queue. Some brought something to read.

GRAPHIC **P2-07**

Cut-paper figures queue at a row of pumps; 1 of 5 pumps dark



The speed limit came down. Nixon first asked for fifty miles an hour. Congress made it fifty-five, nationwide. That limit would stay for more than twenty years.

PHOTO **P2-08** COLOUR

Speed limit road sign by a highway, slow push; numbers 70 → 50 → 55



In January 1974, the clocks went forward for the whole year. Daylight saving in winter. Children walked to school in the dark, to save power in the evening.

GRAPHIC **P2-09**

Odometer-style clock 6:00, 'school in the dark'



And people did drive less. American road fuel use fell nearly four percent in a year. That doesn't sound like much. It was enough to change how a country lived.

VIDEO **P2-10** COLOUR

Highway traffic, light, high angle (toned) + bars overlay



Part of the reason was the cars. In 1973, the average American vehicle did about twelve miles to the gallon. Every queue was full of cars that drank fuel fast.

PHOTO **P2-11** COLOUR

Big 1970s American sedan, slow pan + '11.9 MPG'



On the invoice, line two isn't money. It's hours in a queue, a colder house and darker mornings. America was angry. But Britain had it worse. Why?

GRAPHIC **P2-12**

Receipt line 2: TIME · QUEUES · 68°F



Part three. The dark.

GRAPHIC **P3-01**

Part card 03 'The Dark'



Britain wasn't on the embargo list. But in 1973, oil supplied almost half of the country's energy. And at the same time, its coal miners were in a pay dispute.

GRAPHIC **P3-02**

UK map in orange; oil drop + coal lump icons meet; '46%'



In November, the government asked drivers to keep to fifty miles an hour, and to stay off the roads at weekends. By December, the fifty limit was law.

PHOTO **P3-03** COLOUR · CALM

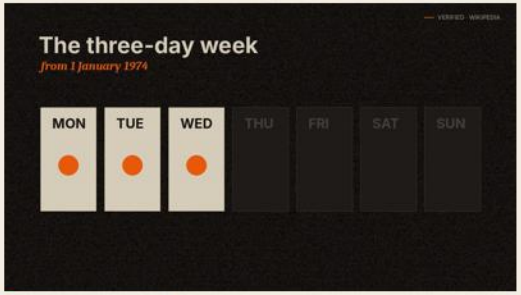
Wet British road with a 50 sign / rainy road, slow push



On the twenty-ninth of November, petrol ration books were handed out to every motorist in the country. They were never used. In July 1975, people were told they could throw them away.

GRAPHIC **P3-04**

Ration-book style card (recreated, no crest) + stamp NEVER USED



Then, on the thirteenth of December, Prime Minister Edward Heath announced the three-day week. From the first of January 1974, businesses could use electricity on just three days a week.

GRAPHIC **P3-05**

Week calendar: 7 days, 4 go dark



Television had to stop at half past ten every night. The government told families to heat only one room. Shops worked by candlelight and paraffin lamps.

PHOTO **P3-06** SHADOW

Candle on a kitchen table in a dark room, slow push



And the price at the pump doubled. In mid-1973, a gallon of British petrol cost thirty-six pence. By the end of 1974, seventy-two.

GRAPHIC **P3-07**

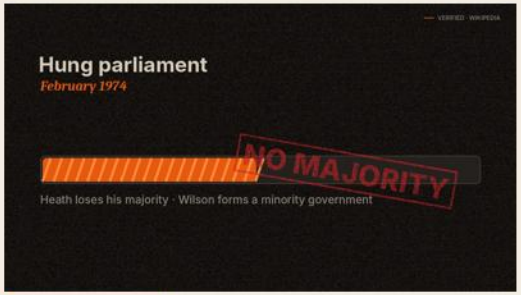
Split-flap 36p → 72p A GALLON



In January, the miners voted to strike. Eighty-one percent said yes. Heath called an election and asked, in effect, who runs the country.

PHOTO **P3-08** COLOUR

Coal mine headframe / pit wheel at dusk, slow push + '81% YES'



He lost his majority. Harold Wilson formed a minority government. The three-day week ended in March. The oil shock and the coal strike had brought down a government in under four months.

GRAPHIC **P3-09**

Seat bar flips from majority to hung parliament (no faces)



Across the sea, the Netherlands was on the embargo list. From the fourth of November 1973, Sundays were car-free. People skated and rode horses on empty motorways.

VIDEO **P3-10** COLOUR · INTENSE

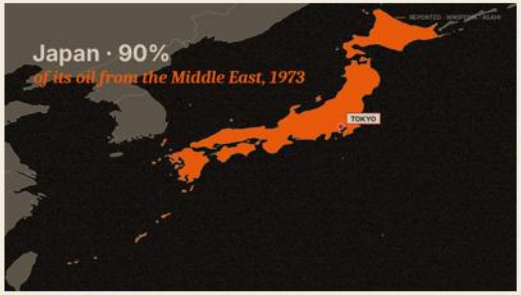
Empty motorway / cyclists on a big road (toned)



Several other European countries banned driving, flying or boating on Sundays too.

GRAPHIC **P3-11**

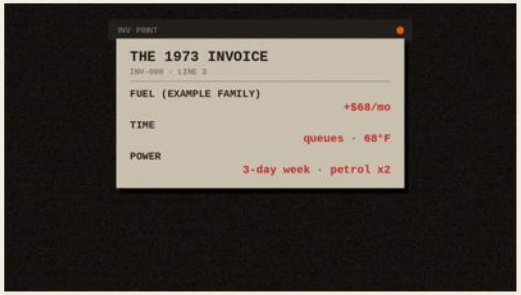
Europe map, several countries tick on with a SUNDAY icon



Japan got about nine tenths of its oil from the Middle East. When its trade minister asked people to save paper, a rumour spread that toilet paper was running out. People rushed the shops, and the rumour made itself true.

GRAPHIC **P3-12**

Dark map: Japan glows; '90% from the Middle East'



Line three on the invoice: power. Lights, heat, and in Britain, a government. But the queues and the candles ended in a few months. The bill didn't. What came after?

GRAPHIC **P3-13**

Receipt line 3: POWER · 3-DAY WEEK · PETROL ×2



Part four. The long bill.

GRAPHIC **P4-01**

Part card 04 'The Long Bill'



The embargo ended in March 1974. The price didn't go back. Oil stayed at the new level, and by November 1974 it was around fifteen dollars a barrel.

GRAPHIC **P4-02**

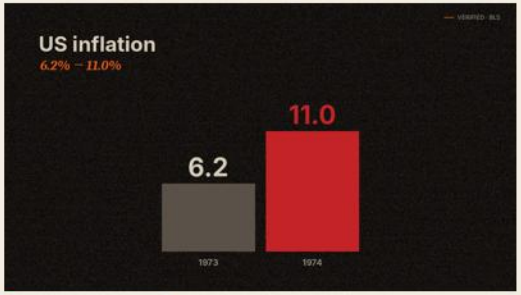
Line chart continues flat-high after Mar 1974 to ~$15



Oil goes into almost everything. Fuel for the lorry that brings the food. Plastic for the packet. Heat for the factory. So the price moved through every shelf.

VIDEO **P4-03** COLOUR

Lorry on a road / goods being loaded (toned)



In America, prices rose about six percent in 1973. In 1974, eleven percent.

GRAPHIC **P4-04**

Columns US CPI 6.2% → 11.0%



For a family spending three thousand dollars a month, that means the same shopping costs about three hundred and thirty dollars more a month, a year later. That's an example, not an average.

PHOTO **P4-05** COLOUR

Supermarket trolley / groceries at checkout, slow push + '+$330'



In Britain it was worse. In the twelve months to June 1975, prices rose twenty-six percent. Something that cost a pound now cost a pound and twenty-six pence.

GRAPHIC **P4-06**

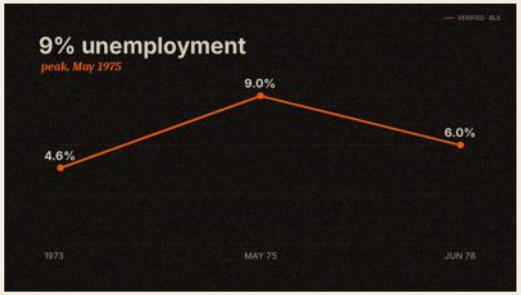
Coin scale £1.00 → £1.26



Then the jobs went. America was in recession from November 1973 to March 1975. About two point three million jobs were lost.

VIDEO **P4-07** SHADOW

Closed factory gates / empty factory floor (shadow grade)



Unemployment kept rising even after the recession ended. It peaked at nine percent in May 1975. It didn't fall below six percent again until June 1978.

GRAPHIC **P4-08**

Line chart unemployment to 9% (May 1975)



In Britain, the economy shrank by around four percent and took three and a half years to recover.

GRAPHIC **P4-09**

Mini tiles: UK GDP -3.9% · 14 quarters



Here's the honest part. Oil didn't start this fire on its own. In mid-1973, before the embargo, American factory prices were already rising more than ten percent a year. Economists still argue how much of the 1970s was oil.

GRAPHIC **P4-10**

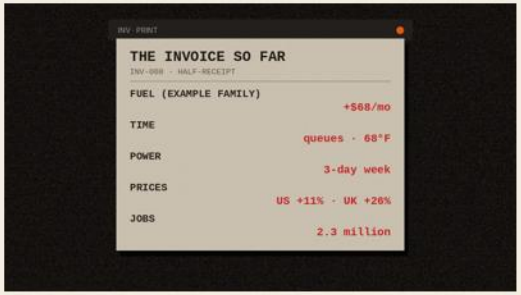
Letter card: 'already rising above 10%' · Fed history (Burns)



What oil did was pour fuel on it. And it showed every government the same thing. A country that can't do without oil can be squeezed by whoever controls it.

VIDEO **P4-11** COLOUR

Oil tanker at sea, slow (toned)



Here is the invoice so far. Fuel, about sixty-eight dollars a month in today's money for our example family. Hours in queues. Power cuts and a fallen government. Prices up eleven percent in America and twenty-six in Britain. Millions of jobs.

GRAPHIC **P4-12**

Half-receipt: four lines + running total



So what did the world do, so that it would never get a bill like this again? And did it work?

GRAPHIC **P4-13**

Shield icon draws in, question



Part five. The fix.

GRAPHIC **P5-01**

Part card 05 'The Fix'



In 1974, the big oil-buying countries set up the International Energy Agency. Each member had to keep oil in storage equal to at least ninety days of its imports.

GRAPHIC **P5-02**

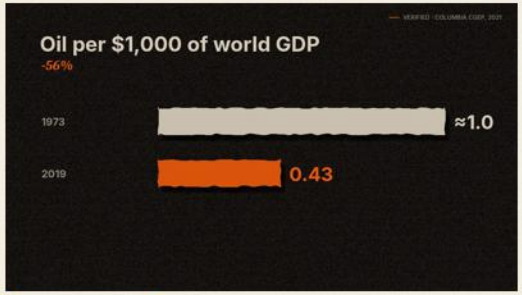
Tank fills to 90 DAYS



In 1975, America created its Strategic Petroleum Reserve, a stock of oil in underground salt caverns. The same law set the first fuel economy rules for cars.

VIDEO **P5-03** COLOUR · CALM

Oil storage tanks (toned)



And slowly, the world learned to do more with less. In 1973, it took a little under one barrel of oil to make a thousand dollars of world output. By 2019, it took less than half a barrel.

GRAPHIC **P5-04**

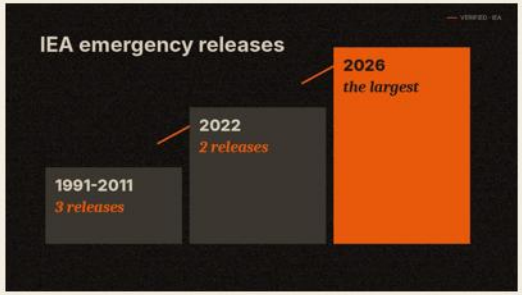
Barrel shrinks 1.0 → 0.43



The biggest change was in America itself. After 1973, it imported more and more. In 1977, OPEC supplied seventy percent of its oil imports. Then shale changed everything. In 2020, America sold more oil products abroad than it bought, for the first time since at least 1949.

VIDEO **P5-05** COLOUR

Oil pumpjacks in a field (shale era), toned



So the 1973 oil crisis left the world a toolkit. Storage, efficiency, and new supply. The emergency stocks have been used together six times. The sixth, in March 2026, was the largest.

GRAPHIC **P5-06**

Steps ladder: 1991 · 2005 · 2011 · 2022 · 2022 · 2026



Which brings us to the question in the title. 2026 took three times more oil off the market than 1973. So why does our bill look so different? And is it really smaller?

GRAPHIC **P5-07**

Versus card 1973 vs 2026 with question mark



Part six. 1973 against 2026.

GRAPHIC **P6-01**

Part card 06 '1973 vs 2026'



In 2026, losses of oil from the Gulf peaked above fourteen million barrels a day. Brent crude went from about seventy-two dollars before the war to a peak above a hundred and twenty-six. A rise of about seventy-four percent.

VIDEO **P6-02** COLOUR · INTENSE

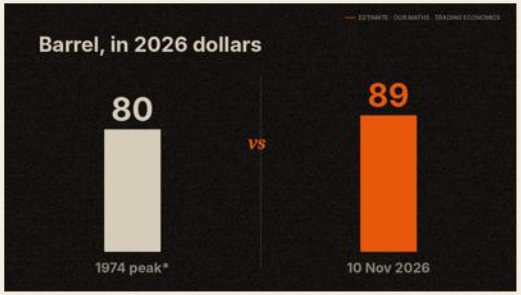
Oil tanker sailing, Gulf haze (toned) + corner '$126'



In 1973, a much smaller loss quadrupled the price. That's the first difference. The world uses less than half as much oil for each dollar it earns, and it had stocks ready. The IEA released four hundred million barrels in March.

GRAPHIC **P6-03**

Scale: ×4 (1973) vs +74% (2026); 400M release



But remember that eighty dollars? The 1974 peak, in today's money. On the tenth of November 2026, even after falling on hopes of a deal, Brent was about eighty-nine. By our maths, oil now costs a little more, in real terms, than at the height of the 1973 oil crisis.

GRAPHIC **P6-04**

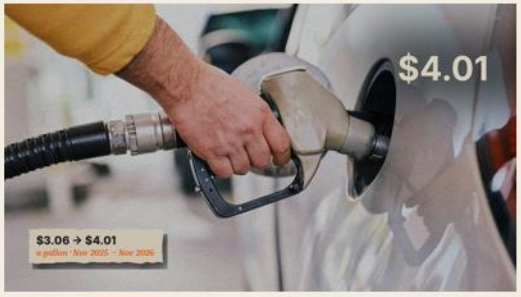
Bars: $80 (1974 in 2026 $) vs $89 (10 Nov 2026)



We just don't queue for it. In 1973, the price was held down by rules, so the fuel ran out. In 2026, the price is allowed to rise, so the fuel is there. We pay at the till, instead of in the queue.

VIDEO **P6-05** COLOUR · INTENSE

Petrol station price board changing (toned)



So how big is our bill? American petrol was about four dollars a gallon on the ninth of November 2026. At Thanksgiving last year, it was about three dollars and six cents.

PHOTO **P6-06** COLOUR

Driver filling a car at a modern pump (hands only), slow push + '$4.01'



Our same example family, buying sixty gallons a month, pays about fifty-seven dollars more a month. In 1974, in today's money, it was about sixty-eight. Close. Not the same, but close.

GRAPHIC **P6-07**

Clipboards: 1974 $68 vs 2026 $57



And a 1974 gallon, in today's money, cost about three dollars seventy-seven. The gallon you buy now costs more than that.

GRAPHIC **P6-08**

Pricetags $3.77 vs $4.01



Prices overall are a different story. In the year to September 2026, US prices rose three point seven percent, and petrol rose thirty-four percent. In 1974, prices overall rose eleven percent. Our oil bill is similar. Our price rise is much smaller, so far.

PHOTO **P6-09** COLOUR

Supermarket price labels on a shelf, slow pan + '3.7%'



For our three-thousand-dollar family, that's about a hundred and eleven dollars more a month, against three hundred and thirty in 1974.

GRAPHIC **P6-10**

Receipt pair: PRICES +$330 vs +$111



Now the worry. America's emergency reserve fell in 2026 to about two hundred and eighty-five million barrels, its lowest since 1982. The cushion that saved us this time is thinner for the next one.

VIDEO **P6-11** SHADOW

Oil tanks / pipes at a storage site, shadow grade + '284.6M'



And 1973 had a sequel. Six years later, in 1979, a second shock pushed oil even higher. The World Bank's bad case for 2026 has world growth falling to one point three percent.

GRAPHIC **P6-12**

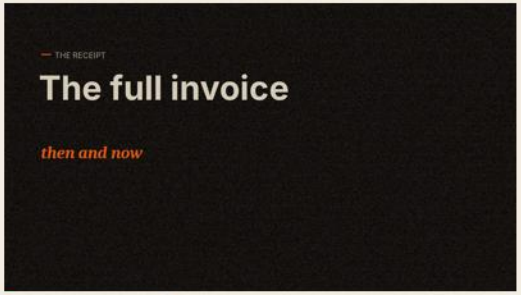
Film-year card 1979: the sequel; World Bank 1.3%



In March 2026, the toilet paper rumour came back in Japan. The paper makers had to tell people that supply was normal. Fifty-three years later, people still remember the queue.

PHOTO **P6-13** COLOUR · CALM

Full supermarket shelves of toilet paper, slow push



So what does the full invoice look like, then and now?

GRAPHIC P6-14

Receipt printer starts



The Receipt. Two columns. 1974 on the left, in today's money. 2026 on the right. Our example family. These are illustrations, not averages.

GRAPHIC RC-01

THE RECEIPT, two columns 1974 / 2026



Line one. Fuel. About sixty-eight dollars more a month in 1974. About fifty-seven in 2026.

GRAPHIC RC-02

Receipt line 1 FUEL



Line two. Prices. About three hundred and thirty dollars more a month in 1974. About a hundred and eleven in 2026, so far.

GRAPHIC RC-03

Receipt line 2 PRICES



Line three. Time. In 1974, hours in queues. In 2026, none, because we pay in price instead.

GRAPHIC RC-04

Receipt line 3 TIME



Line four. Jobs. Two point three million in America in the 1970s. In 2026, not counted yet.

GRAPHIC RC-05

Receipt line 4 JOBS



Line five. The cushion. In 1973, no emergency stocks. In 2026, stocks, but the American reserve at its lowest since 1982.

GRAPHIC **RC-06**

Receipt line 5 CUSHION + stamp



What can you do? This is not financial advice. But some things are always sensible. Keep a buffer of three to six months of essential bills. Test your budget with fuel and food twenty percent higher.

VIDEO **RC-07** COLOUR · CALM

Hands with a notebook / budget and calculator at a table (toned)



If your next car or boiler is due, look at what it burns. The 1970s family with the twelve-mile-a-gallon car paid the most. And don't trade on headlines. Oil falls fast on talk of a deal, and it can rise just as fast.

PHOTO **RC-08** COLOUR · CALM

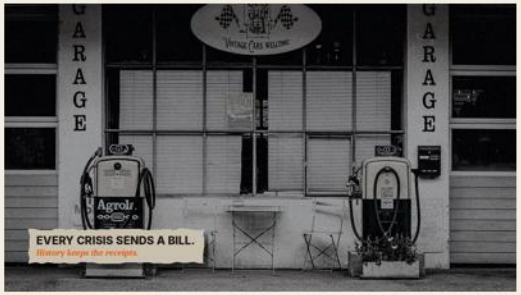
Car dashboard fuel gauge, slow push



Tell us in the comments. Do you remember 1973, or do your parents? Or what did your last fill-up cost? Country and number.

GRAPHIC **RC-09**

Comment card: 'Do you remember 1973?'



In Oregon, the flags came down in the spring of 1974. The price never did. Every crisis sends a bill. History keeps the receipts.

PHOTO **RC-10** SHADOW

Return to the CO-01 old pump, flag gone; fade to black + tagline